

The_Survey_A_Method_for_Bounded_Work

The Survey — a method for bounded work

A method for holding several bodies of work at once without letting them contaminate one another. It is a survey rather than a map: a map depicts terrain, a survey establishes boundaries and produces a description precise enough to convey to someone else.

1 · Zones, plots, and the line between them

A **zone** is a domain of work with its own rules about what may enter and leave. A **plot** is a subdivision inside a zone. The distinction that makes the whole method work is this: **a parent names its children and their boundaries, and never their contents.**

That single rule governs indexes, logs, and conversation alike. It is what allows a body of work to be genuinely separable and genuinely contained at the same time.

Containment without merger. A zone sits inside a larger zone and keeps its own boundary, its own index, and its own record. This repeats at every scale — a workspace inside a workspace, a subdivision inside a domain, an option inside a decision. Every level is a fence around something that is still inside something else.

2 · The lock

Passage between zones is not a bridge. It is a lock: **entry, closure, deliberate level change, release.**

A bridge only opens or closes. A lock does the work in between — nothing is pushed across a boundary; it is brought to the far side's level first, and then let through.

Rule	What it requires before acting
The portability test	Does this describe <i>how the work is done</i> , or <i>what a domain owns</i> ? Only the former travels
Direction	One direction is ordinarily sanctioned; the other requires explicit authorisation. Default deny
Finality	The fork is one-way and permanent. It does not re-merge
Slips	A boundary slip caught at the gate is the system working. That is what the gate is for
Proof	The lock is only real if it holds when a crossing is requested directly

A crossing that is never recorded cannot be shown to have held. Every release should log what crossed, in which direction, on whose authority, and — the column that matters — **what was withheld**. The withheld column is the evidence.

3 · Abutments

Every unit of work records where its edge meets another's. Four columns, and no fifth:

An abutment is a shared line, walked and marked. It is not a merger. Naming one does not open it; several should be recorded as sealed, with the reason attached. A boundary that has never been walked is not a boundary — it is an assumption.

4 · The readout

Zones are not only containers. Read radially, they are a **diagnostic**: each sector reports on the health of what it holds, and the centre is the one element permitted in every sector — the person whose judgment is the only thing that actually crosses.

This yields something a set-overlap diagram cannot: **an address**. Depth and sector together locate a thing. A record of decisions needs an address, because a decision without a location in the structure cannot be found again.

Two statuses that are not failures:

- **Stale by design** — a unit opened with its record and its next step written, waiting for real work. A stale entry there is correct.
- **Absent by design** — a boundary deliberately holding nothing. Record the emptiness so it reads as a decision rather than an oversight. **An empty sector on a survey is still surveyed.**

5 · Terms mean what their sector says

The same term can resolve differently on either side of a boundary. When it does, the abbreviation is an unlabelled boundary and must be replaced by the words themselves.

This is why a flat glossary fails. One entry with a footnote is the wrong shape; two linked entries, each addressed to its own sector, is the right one. **A term is not defined — it is located.**

6 · The record

Rule	Why
Open the record at inception, never retrofit	Retrofitting loses the wrong turns, and the wrong turns are the asset
The artifact is the source of truth, not recollection	Working from memory of a standard is unauditable and decays silently
One source of truth per artifact	One generator feeding many surfaces. Two hand-maintained copies drift, and the copy nobody reads is the one that rots
Mark what was inferred	An inferred value must never pass as a stated one
Register decisions with their authority	The difference between a decision and a habit is whether anyone authorised it
Dated snapshots, never silent overwrites	The set of snapshots is the difference
Do not rewrite the record to match a new frame	A record says what it said when it was written. Retro-editing history to fit a better idea is corruption wearing the clothes of tidiness

7 • Good fences

The boundary that is maintained when nothing is currently pressing against it is the one that holds when something is. A wall with no present function, mended anyway, is not waste — the mending is the discipline, and the discipline is what remains when a crossing is finally requested.

Before building a boundary, be able to say what is being kept in and what is being kept out. A boundary whose purpose cannot be stated is inherited, not chosen — and an inherited boundary will not survive the first argument against it.

Distillations

- The canal is its locks: controlled passage, one gate at a time.
- A lock equalises before it releases.
- A parent names its children and their boundaries, never their contents.
- An abutment is a shared line, not a merger.
- An empty sector on a survey is still surveyed.
- A term is not defined; it is located.
- The withheld column is the evidence.
- A boundary that has never been walked is an assumption.